the Afghanistan they were trying to rule. ‘Our apathy in this respect is disgraceful,’ he exclaimed,

> and so is our ignorance of the institutions and manners of the country. When a country is invaded, its resources are always used by the conquering army, the leader of which assumes the government. Lord Wellington administered the civil government of the South of France, collecting the revenues and appointing every functionary. After four years of occupation we are as little prepared to do that effectually here as in 1838; less so, for the desire to learn is diminished, as all think we are soon to quit the country . . . To acquire accurate information of the real resources of the country, the modes of collection, and the rights of the various classes in relation to the State and to each other, never seems to have been thought necessary . . . Consequently, we fail from our ignorance.[36]

Soon after their arrival in Kabul, the two officers were invited to meet Macnaghten and Burnes, and they told them something of their impressions. But ‘the Envoy took no notice of any of these warnings’, wrote Mackenzie, ‘and Burnes did not like to interfere further: his views were, except in the details, those of Macnaghten, and he was nearly as blind as to what was passing around him’.[37] Instead, Macnaghten, ever keen on ceremonial, organised for them to be accorded a grand Bala Hisar reception by Shuja, who he said wished to thank them for safely bringing in his women and treasure, and to present them both with ‘a horse, a sword and a dress of honour’.[38]

Mackenzie was appalled by the whole farce, and wrote to his in-laws in Calcutta telling Thoby Prinsep that he believed the occupation in its current form was now untenable and that the whole situation was most ‘alarming . . . our gallant fellows in Afghanistan must be immediately reinforced, or they will perish’.[39]

While waiting for his begums to arrive, Shah Shuja had decided to turn his charm on another young woman. ‘Most sacred Queen, whose banner is the Sun,’ wrote Shuja to Queen Victoria around this time. ‘My Kind and Illustrious Sister, may the Almighty God preserve her! I had the pleasure to receive the congratulatory letter which Your Majesty, out of the excess of your kindness and friendship, wrote me conveying the joyful accounts of your health and prosperity. This caused the garden of affection to bring forth an increase of excellent fruit.’